SOFTWARE ARCHITECTURE INSIGHTS

# Where Is Your AI System, Really?

A five-level self-check. One system, a few yes-or-no questions per level, about ten minutes.

**How to use it.** Pick the one system where AI matters most to your business. Grade that one system. Start at Level 2 and work up. Check a box only if you could show someone the evidence today. You're at the highest level where every box is checked.

## 1 Attached · where everyone starts

The model is called straight from the code that needed it. The prompt lives in the handler. Search your codebase for vendor SDK imports. If they're scattered across features, added by whoever needed one that week, you're here.

## 2 Shipped · where most enterprises are today

- [ ] Real users use the AI feature in production.
- [ ] The prompt lives in a repository.

## 3 Measured

- [ ] An evaluation set exists, built from what users actually do.
- [ ] Someone outside engineering agreed to an acceptance threshold.
- [ ] You know what one transaction costs in inference, and someone owns that number.
- [ ] You can say, with numbers, what the last model update did to your accuracy.

## 4 Designed

- [ ] A verification layer checks outputs, with written behavior for low confidence.
- [ ] Model choice is a recorded decision with a named owner. Requests go to the smallest model that clears the bar.
- [ ] Every context source has a freshness limit and enforces today's permissions.
- [ ] The model sits behind a boundary. When you swap it, your test harness tells you what changed.
- [ ] Every gap you know about is written down as accepted debt.

## 5 Default · the whole organization

- [ ] Your newest AI system started from the last one's boundary, harness and routing.
- [ ] Owning evaluation and the context supply chain are standing roles. They don't depend on one person who happened to care.
- [ ] Design reviews ask about AI behavior and cost the way they ask about availability.

**My system is at Level _____.** The slide says Level _____.

Most organizations land about two levels below the slide. Level 2 looks like Level 4 from the outside, because the demo works at both.